The multiplicity of places of worship in India gives Hindus plenty of choice, and affords religious-minded temple-goers opportunities for extensive pilgrimages. Most Hindu families embark on these quite often; for some, the only holidays they undertake are to temple towns, to worship at the shrine of a powerful deity. While some pilgrimages, especially to well-established temple towns, take on the characteristics of a religious holiday, others can be quite arduous. The annual *yatra* to the ice-cave at Amarnath in Kashmir involves a major trek; that of Mount Kailash and Lake Mansarovar in Tibet, renowned as the abode of Shiva, has cost the lives of many of who have attempted it across the narrow and treacherous Himalayan passes. Pilgrimages to Kedarnath and Badrinath, and to the sources of the Ganga and the Yamuna at Gangotri and Yamunotri respectively, are other Himalayan journeys that are not for the weak or faint-hearted. Other religious trips are to sites where large numbers of Hindus gather for a special occasion: from the Thrissur Pooram, an annual festival which involves the largest processional of caparisoned elephants in the world (usually up to a hundred pachyderms decked up to the hilt), to the *ratha-yatra* at the Jagannath temple in Puri, Odisha and the Kumbh Melas described below. *Utsava*s (religious festivals, from the Sanskrit '*ut*', to let go or remove, and '*sava*', worldly sorrows, hence an occasion to release one's burdens or cares) abound across the country. Regional festivals witness throngs of worshippers in different parts of the country on different occasions at fixed times of the year—Bengalis celebrating Durga Puja, Maharashtrians Ganesh Chaturthi, the Ram Leela across north India, Onam in Kerala, Pongal in Tamil Nadu. Holi, the festival of colours, is famously the most fun-filled of all *utsava*s, while an occasion like Makar Sankranti, marking the transit of the sun into the Makara rashi (Capricorn—sign of the zodiac) in Hindu astrology, is observed with due solemnity. The largest crowds gather during the Kumbha Melas that take place every twelve years in Haridwar, Allahabad (Prayag), Nasik, and Ujjain: the Allahabad Kumbh, at the confluence of the Ganga and the Yamuna, is an extraordinary sight, attracting some twenty million people each time.

Sometimes a pilgrimage may consist of a regular visit to one favourite temple: the Kerala political leader K. Karunakaran travelled to the